

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2024 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Jenny Guarino

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council District 2

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. Missing Middle housing**
- b. San Pablo specific plan**
- c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave**

I support the Missing Middle Housing proposed by the Planning Commission, and the alternative put forward by Councilmember Lunaparra at the 7/23 Council meeting. Additionally, I support upzoning along the transit and commercial corridors mentioned. Building new apartment buildings in North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave would go a long way to affirmatively furthering fair housing and combating racial segregation.

The development and execution of the San Pablo Specific Plan will be critical for defining District 2 for years to come. I am committed to ensuring the plan prioritizes high density housing along San Pablo, specific investments in affordable housing by the City, bicycle and pedestrian improvements along and leading to San Pablo including traffic calming on San Pablo itself, and investments in new and revitalized green space. The City must prioritize fulfilling the goals outlined in our sixth cycle Housing Element.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building

Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings. Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

The Climate Action Plan is great, but it is far easier to put a plan in place than to fund and execute it. Especially given that the City's largest source of greenhouse gas emissions is transportation, I support the Bicycle and Pedestrian plans and view them as a strong priority for infrastructure funding. I support Measure GG, though I recognize concerns about its impacts on nonprofits and arts and would seek to revise and mitigate some of the details of the tax if it passes. The Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program is a great way to implement the "just transition," investing in improvements that simultaneously reduce emissions, improve the lives of poor and middle class residents, and provide good union jobs. I support increasing funding to this program. I also support the BAAQMD's NOx standards, and would oppose efforts to delay them or water them down.

Other policies I support:

- Adopt interim policy measures to fill the vacuum left by overturning of the natural gas ban.
- Amending the Building Energy Savings Ordinance to require reasonable and cost-effective mandatory electrification and building envelope measures upon the sale of certain properties.
- Formalizing policies that will encourage utility and neighborhood-scale gas system pruning following retrofits.
- Supporting a potential policy and community organizing effort (in consultation with the City Attorney's office and AVA Energy) to initiate a Prop. 218 process to secure support from residents and businesses to explore cost neutral options to electrify buildings.
- Partnering with AC Transit to expand access and service for Berkeley residents, such as providing free AC Transit for Berkeley residents on certain times or days of the week.
- Continuing to commit Uber/Lyft tax revenues to mobility transit upgrades at bus stations and bus lanes, and for bus rapid transit upgrades.
- Implementing Car Free Telegraph Avenue.
- Piloting electric vehicle charging at the street level to help support tenants and homeowners without garages with low-cost level 2 charging in residential preferred parking zones.

- Expediting the transition of the City's small vehicle fleet to zero-emission, and investing in finding zero-emission alternatives to larger and more specialized vehicles like garbage disposal trucks.
- Expanding partnerships with AVA, including more municipally owned electric car charging stations, and grants for private charging stations.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I would say a combination of passing the Demolition Ordinance and moving forward the Missing Middle zoning changes. In my opinion, the Planning Commission struck the perfect balance by recommending strong versions of both – it is critical that we allow for infill housing that adds density throughout our community while providing protections against displacement and loss of affordability as we do so. My hope is that the passage of the Demolition Ordinance will reduce some of the conflict between those concerned about tenants protections and gentrification and advocates for density. I hope to finalize the Missing Middle zoning changes on Council.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The adoption of the Natural Gas Ban in new development was a huge achievement and became a model that was followed around the country and the globe. While the courts have, I believe wrongly, given us a temporary setback in striking down the specifics of our ban, I support revising the law to account for the court ruling.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

I discuss my support for walking and biking infrastructure in the next question. Additionally, I support dense new transit-oriented housing at the North Berkeley and Ashby BART station parking lots, and would like to see the City maximize its funding for affordable housing at Ashby BART. I support the City partnering with AC Transit to help fund bus shelters and benches. I support expanding micro-mobility options, including grants for electric bikes for low income residents and finding an alternative to GIG Car Share so residents can live mostly car-free while being able to access a car when necessary.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking.

Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

I am very much in favor of Measure FF, and helped campaign for it with my union, UAW 4811. Making our ENTIRE city safe for walking and biking is both a basic public safety priority and critical for addressing climate change. I recently got to speak with a number of parents with young children at a block party in D2, and multiple raised the issue of bike and pedestrian safety as a priority for investment. The 2017 Bicycle Plan suggested that some 90% of Berkeley residents would consider biking if only it were safe to do so. Making our neighborhoods safe for walking and biking is an investment in our community's future. Additionally, I don't think that Measure EE will raise sufficient funds, and has an unworkable and overly complicated oversight structure.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

All in all, inclusionary zoning is a fragile solution to a complicated, multifaceted issue. If inclusionary zoning requirements are too high, development can stall and the City may get no new affordable units. I recognize that inclusionary zoning is a flawed tool, but because of the restrictions of Prop 13 it is one of the only effective tools we have for meeting our need and state requirements for affordable housing. Additionally, on site inclusionary units are an important tool of integration and desegregation. I think this is especially important for District 2, along with Right to Return policies, to ensure that new development includes units that are

accessible to those displaced from our community. In-lieu fees are a good option for the Southside neighborhood, where gentrification is less of a concern and affordable housing may not be as suited to student buildings. In general, I favor on site units in South and Southwest Berkeley, and the fee in Downtown and the Southside.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

Fire risk in the hills is driven by narrow winding roads and street parking, not the density of housing itself. In moderately high fire risk zones increase in density should be coupled with expanded red curbing. Only Zone 3, the highest risk area, should have strict limits on new building.

While I understand the risk around increasing density in high-fire risk zones, exempting the Hillside Overlay is a political ploy that only entrenches Berkeley's original sin of segregationist single family zoning. I believe the City can strike a balance to investigate and mitigate the risks of evacuation in high fire-risk areas while also encouraging the development of new housing in the whitest, most affluent parts of Berkeley. With Missing Middle specifically, I believe the Council should adopt the Planning Commission version of Missing Middle and temporarily delay high fire zone areas until an evacuation study is completed and street parking is removed on narrow streets.